

A Beginner's Guide To AWS S3 Storage

AWS S3 is the foundational cloud storage service you will use on almost every project. Learning how to properly store, secure, and manage files here is a must-have skill for any cloud engineer.

What you'll learn:

- 1 Creating Your First S3 Bucket
- 2 Uploading and Downloading Files
- 3 Locking Down Public Access
- 4 Listing Bucket Contents

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Creating Your First S3 Bucket

A bucket is simply a container for your files in the cloud. Because S3 buckets are shared across the entire world, your bucket name must be 100% unique. Think of it like naming a website domain; if someone else took the name, you need to pick a new one. You can create one easily using the AWS Command Line Interface.

```
$aws s3 mb s3://my-learning-bucket-abc12345
```

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Uploading and Downloading Files

Once your bucket exists, you can treat it like a remote hard drive. You use the copy command to send files from your local computer up to the cloud, or download them back down when needed. This is the exact mechanism developers use to push application assets and backups.

```
$aws s3 cp index.html s3://my-learning-bucket-abc12345/
```

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Locking Down Public Access

By default, AWS keeps all S3 buckets strictly private so the public cannot peek inside. This is a great security feature to prevent accidental data leaks. If you ever need to share files publicly, you have to explicitly turn off these safety blocks and apply special permissions.

```
$aws s3api put-public-access-block --bucket my-learning-bucket-abc12345 --public-access-block-configuration
```

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Listing Bucket Contents

As your storage grows, you will need a quick way to see what files live inside your bucket without logging into the web console. The list command lets you view everything stored in your bucket directly from your terminal in seconds.

```
$aws s3 ls s3://my-learning-bucket-abc12345/
```


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Key Takeaways

- + Always enable S3 versioning on production buckets to prevent accidental file deletion.
- + Use descriptive, environment-specific names for your buckets (e.g., company-app-logs-prod).
- + Set up lifecycle rules early so old logs and temp files delete themselves automatically.
- + Keep public access blocked on 99% of your buckets unless hosting a public website.
- + Learn to use the AWS CLI alongside the web console for faster daily workflows.

Watch Out For

- ! Leaving public access wide open on a bucket containing private company data.
- ! Forgetting that S3 bucket names must be globally unique across all AWS users.
- ! Uploading massive datasets without checking your AWS data transfer and storage pricing.

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